PROPS DESIGN

Props Design: Period, Function and Symbol

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

A prop is never only an object: how period research, practical function and symbolic weight are balanced in a design, with examples from Nigerian stages.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- period research
- practicality
- symbol
- colour and scale
- the hero prop

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Research the object, not the era

Period research for props means answering: what was this made of, who made it, how much did it cost, and who would have owned one? A 1960s Lagos parlour has a particular radio, a particular wall clock and a particular kind of pressed-glass cup; getting those three right does more than a room full of generically old furniture.

Photographs, market stalls, family houses and the national archives are better sources than costume books, which usually stop at the drawing room.

Practicality wins arguments

A prop that does not work will destroy the scene it appears in: a phone that does not ring, a letter that cannot be read, a bottle that is obviously empty. Decide what the object must do, then find the object that does it. If nothing does, build the function into the prop and hide the mechanism.

Weight is a design decision. A case that is supposed to be heavy and is carried lightly tells the audience it is cardboard. Add weight, or rehearse the carry so the actor's body tells the truth.

The hero prop

Most plays have one object the action turns on: the letter in The Importance of Being Earnest, the pistol in Miss Julie, the papers in a political drama. The hero prop should be designed, not found: it needs a look that can be seen from the back row, a place it is kept, and a handling that the audience learns to watch.

Give the hero prop a journey. If it enters in act one and is still on the table in act two, the audience stops noticing it; if it is hidden, found, half-burned and returned, they will follow it.

Symbol without posters

A prop becomes symbolic when the play has already given it weight, not when it is explained. A white cloth is a shroud because of what happens around it, not because the programme says so. Choose objects that can carry the play's argument and then let the staging do the work: place it, use it, take it away.

In Nigerian drama the staff, the calabash, the kolanut and the wrapper carry meanings already, and a designer who uses them must know which meanings and for whom. A masquerade staff on a domestic set is not decoration; it is a claim.

Props and the actor's body

An actor needs time with a prop before an audience sees it. Give them the object in the first week of rehearsal, not the dress rehearsal: a phone that must be answered in three rings, a bag that must be searched, a knife that must be held convincingly all need practice, and practice is what makes an object look owned.

Decide the handling as part of the blocking. Where is the prop kept when it is not used? How is it picked up? Does the character treat it carelessly or carefully, and what does that say? An actor who fidgets with a prop is telling you the prop has no business, so give it one.

Safety is part of the design: no real glass, no real flames without a fire officer, no blade that has not been checked, and no food that has been sitting under stage lights for two hours. Rehearse the dangerous moments slowly, and

rehearse the moment before the dangerous moment, because that is where accidents are made.

Exercises

1. Choose one play and identify its hero prop. Write the prop's journey through the play in six movements.
2. Research three objects from a Nigerian household in 1965 and document them with sources.
3. Design a symbolic prop for a scene, then stage the scene twice with and without it, and describe the difference.

Where to read more

Andrew Sofer, The Stage Life of Props (2003)

Amy Mussman, The Prop Master (2008)

Yemi Ogunbiyi (ed.), Drama and Theatre in Nigeria (1981)

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